

Vertigo

No 812 November 2017



NEW ZEALAND
ALPINE CLUB

Wellington Section Monthly Bulletin

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Dawn at about 1,700m, climbing an eastern snow face towards the northeast ridge of Mount Travers - Peter Laurenson

Chair's Report

November 2017

With the change in government it's time to impose a tourist tax. DoC is underfunded and our tramping environment is being trashed. DoC don't have the resources or capacity to put in the infrastructure required to meet the significant increase in demand, nor manage the overuse of existing facilities.

Complaints from the commercial sector about driving away their business are rubbish and only demonstrate their short term greed over long term sustainability. As the world's 'wild places' continue to shrink little ol NZ is growing exponentially in popularity. We need to preserve this for ourselves as well as the tourists and, giving it away for free isn't the way to do it. As we know with just about anything that's free, people will keep taking it till its all gone.

It isn't just overuse that's an issue. Landowners are also pushing back, increasingly blocking access to crags and other areas we like to play in. Maintaining access on agreeable terms also requires resources. John Palmer highlighted how serious this is becoming in his recent section night presentation. So come on David Parker, I know you will be reading this as a person with an avid interest in all things outdoors, wrap your economic and environment portfolios together and slap on the tourist tax now.

Don't forget to get your tickets to this year's Reel Rock showing this month. Details in this edition of Vertigo. And finally: "Here is your country. Cherish these natural wonders, cherish the natural resources, cherish the history and romance as a sacred heritage, for your children and your children's children. Do not let selfish men or greedy interests skin your country of its beauty, its riches or its romance." Theodore Roosevelt

If you have any comments on what you like or don't like send an email to wellington@alpineclub.org.nz or tweet us [@NZACWellington](https://twitter.com/NZACWellington).

Simon

From the Editor

This is the last Vertigo for 2017, so a very happy Christmas to all readers and your families. Hopefully I'll receive some trip reports from some of you to feature in the January edition. All you need to do is type up a report of between half a page to three pages as a Word document, email it to me at occasionalclimber@gmail.com with one to six jpeg images and I'll format it for Vertigo.

Don't forget the page quicklinks at the base of each page - they let you go straight to the page you want rather than having to scroll back and forth all the time.

Peter

Simon Williamson
Chair: NZAC Wellington

Section News

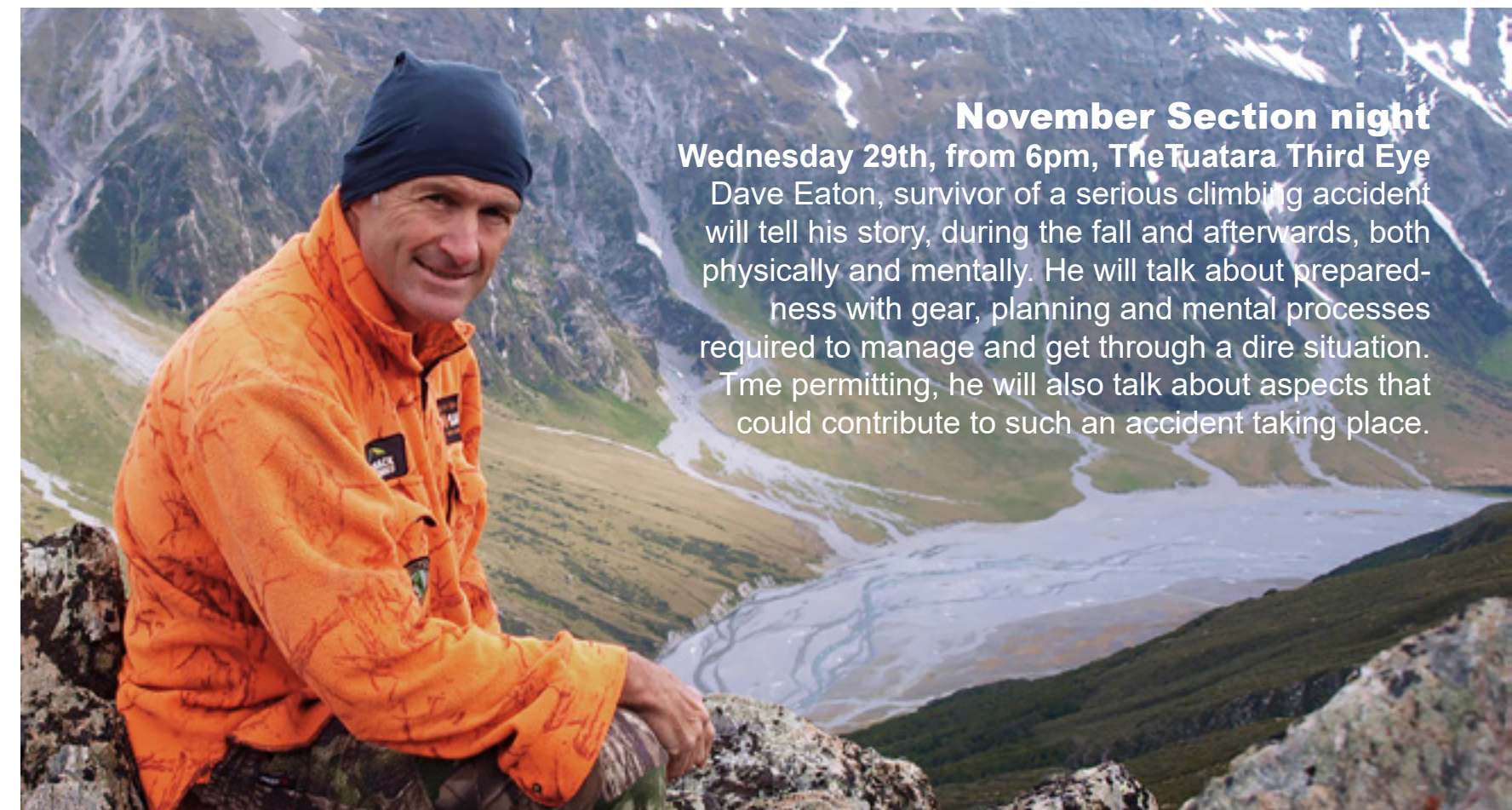
October Section night

The AGM for the Wellington Section of the NZ Alpine Club took place during our section night on Wednesday 25th October 2017 at the Tuatara Third Eye. There were 18 in attendance.

The annual accounts for FY 2016/17 were tabled and accepted. A big thank you to Blair Smith and his team at Blackler Smith & Co for preparing our accounts and, in so doing, bringing us into the 21st Century in terms of automation and ease of future preparation.



The Committee for FY 2017/18 was confirmed, along with some new Committee members. For details see [Section Contacts](#).



November Section night Wednesday 29th, from 6pm, The Tuatara Third Eye

Dave Eaton, survivor of a serious climbing accident will tell his story, during the fall and afterwards, both physically and mentally. He will talk about preparedness with gear, planning and mental processes required to manage and get through a dire situation. Time permitting, he will also talk about aspects that could contribute to such an accident taking place.

Section nights beyond November

There will be no Section nights in December or January because, hopefully, we'll all be too busy climbing.

Our gathering in February will be at Hangdogs, where climbing and pizza consumption can occur. In March we are back at the Third Eye, to hear from John Phillips about his climb of Acongagua - the highest peak in South America. April is still being confirmed but, in May, Marcus Thomas will present his spectacular Cave book.

More details about February and other Section nights will be available in the January Vertigo.

Section News

Gear Hire

Don't forget the Section has gear for hire: avalanche transceivers, ice axes, shovels, stakes, hammers, helmets, crampons, probes, PLBs, ice hammers (entry level).

To hire gear please fill in the form [here](#).

Each item costs \$5 per week with the exception of PLBs – PLBs are free but require a deposit of \$50 refundable on return.

A little bit of advance notice would be appreciated as gear often needs to be retrieved from the gear store in Lower Hutt. Gear collections and drop-offs are usually available in the city during the working day or at section night.

Accommodation on Mt Ruapehu

Our snowcraft courses for the past few years have been run out of the Manawatu Tramping and Skiing Club lodge on Whakapapa. We're always made to feel welcome and the lodge is well situated a short walk from the top of the Bruce Road. Membership to the club is extremely reasonable - \$35 per year or \$50 for a family membership. Members stay at the lodge for \$36 a night including food. If you're looking for somewhere to base yourself for your winter pursuits or rock-climbing over the summer months go to www.mtsc.org.nz/joining.php to find out more about joining the club.



Heading to Mt Cupola, Nelson Lakes

Notices

Himalayan maps to go

Peter Phol, based in Lower Hutt, has a small collection of good condition Kashmir and Nepal maps. They are not recent but the mountains haven't moved much. Free to a good home - contact p.pohl@orcon.net.nz

The Conquest of Everest

Extraordinary colour footage shot by Tom Stobart and George Lowe, with aerial photography provided by the Indian Air Force. Academy Award nomination in "Best Documentary Feature" 1954. 7pm, Wednesday 29 and Thursday 30 November
Nga Taonga Sound & Vision Cinema, 84 Taranaki St, Wellington
Tickets \$10/\$8, available through [Eventfinda](#).

FMC offers safety training scholarships for new Pack-rafters Read [more](#).

FREE PDF download - NEW EDITION NZ Alpine Journal Index

This is the fourth edition of the Index to the New Zealand Alpine Journal; earlier editions were published in 1975, 1977 and 1987. This 2017 edition is available via the internet as a pdf file from the NZAC website [here](#).

2018 NZAC calendar now on sale

With all the winning images from the 2017 Photo Competition. The perfect alternative to a Christmas Card with \$5 postage to anywhere in the world included in the online price. Pick-up from National Office less this amount. Place an [order](#).

Jan Bolwell's new play Taking the High Ground

The play delves into the lives of two outstanding climbers. Freda du Faur, an Australian, was the first woman to scale Aoraki/Mount Cook in 1910. Lydia Bradey, a New Zealander, was the first woman to scale Mount Everest solo and without oxygen in 1988. Taking the High Ground opens at Bats Theatre for its premiere season from 5-9th December. Tickets can be purchased through the [Bats website](#).

Missing long-handled ice-axes

NZAC National Office is missing two old long-handled ice-axes from our Library display, most likely lent out for a past funeral guard of honour? We would really like them returned – no questions asked. Drop in, or send to Margaret at Unit 6/6 Raycroft St, Waltham, Christchurch 8140, or contact office@alpineclub.org.nz to arrange alternative delivery.

UIAA ice climbing season

The provisional calendar for the 2018 UIAA Ice Climbing season is now in place. Read [more](#).

2017 Mountain Protection Award

The 2017 Mountain Protection Award has just announced 26 projects from 15 countries who have applied - to see what other countries are doing read [more](#).

Coming Trips, Courses, Events

All our planned South Island trips come with the added bonus that rental vehicle costs for Wellington Section members are covered by the Section.

If you're uncertain about the skill level required with any of the trips, would like to register your interest or to find out more, email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

Also, please contact us if you're keen to run a trip yourself – the Committee can help with advertising and logistics.

When	Where
14 and 21 November Two screenings on consecutive Tuesdays, commencing 6pm	Reel Rock - back for a second year by popular demand. Nga Taonga Sound & Vision Cinema, 84 Taranaki St Tickets \$19 members, \$21 non members, \$14 Under 15s Get in quick, cinema seats 107 only. Book your tickets: For Tuesday 14 Nov here For Tuesday 21 Nov here Please note - we're using Eventopia to process all bookings online. Eventopia applies a handling fee per ticket of between \$1.60 and \$1.78
17 to 20 November	Rock climbing meet, Paynes Ford, contact Eric to find out more 021 350 161
2 - 6 February 2018	The National Climbing Camp, Tukino, based at TASC Lodge

Outdoor Training NZ Courses

OTNZ Wellington is running training courses as follows:

River Safety (3 December)

Course covers understanding river dynamics and hazards, how to evaluate sites for safe crossing, methods of crossing, preparing clothing and equipment for a crossing, managing a group crossing, pack floating and how to self-rescue if swept away.

More information on these courses and how to book your place can be found at www.outdoortraining.nz/courses/courses.php.

Trip Reports



Here he is - on lead again

Where's Eric?

Wellington Section Sports Climbing Trip, Payne's Ford, Golden Bay, Labour Weekend
By Jenny Cossey

The trip moved from Mount Sommers to Paynes Ford when Jetstar announced some super cheap airfares to Nelson over Labour weekend, that left Wellington late Friday afternoon. The team of seven were in the supermarket, stove fuel purchased and over Takaha hill in daylight to pitch tents at dusk and eat a wonderful vegan meal as darkness descended and the stars came out. Hangdog was very quiet all weekend. We had a table to ourselves, cold nights and lots of quiet sleep (apart from the road noise).

The plan was a warm, shady day of climbing at Creese Wall and Stone Symposium on Saturday (our group had the walls to ourselves for many hours). A day sun basking at Cathedral Wall, Pohara on Sunday and an 8am start on Monday for a few hours of mileage climbing at Little Lost Wall before any other climbers arrived. We left Hangdog at noon to catch the 2.45pm flight home.

Eric announced he was keen to do mileage within the 16 to 22 grades, hence we all did mileage. With two Payne's virgins, and a great forecast the team was keen. Scarlet and Marie with one rope technique sessions on Kaurangi School playground 2.5 metre high fort and a practice day at Pukura Bay, led the enthusiasm league by immediately leading and abseiling off routes without a top rope warm up led by others. It was Scarlet's second day on rock. Using old school style boldness with excellent modern rope technique, she made an impression on all of us, as well as being a wonderful sober driver.

Super strong Marie thought Eric's grade 19 over hanging jugs looked like excellent upskilling opportunities and with boisterous glee shot up them, while others looked on. Eric's hands loved slopers, everyone else debated if the sloping surfaces were actually holds. Paul started as Eric's first belayer, and as Eric's enthusiasm increased we all held his rope so that Paul could have a rest and the rest of us contemplated our enthusiasm to follow Eric's lead on top rope. Eric meanwhile had already disappeared around another corner with another rope, ready to lead, while a belayer had to run and search for him, with the cry "Where's Eric?"

Alexis and Elisha were a communicate climbing pair and discussed many things as they contemplated the universe. Everyone pushed themselves leading on dry, warm rock with few other climbers about, or top roping following one of Eric's numerous routes as he continued doing mileage.

Long days on the crags required recovery sessions in the hot tubs and sauna of 95 degrees, the hottest that most of us had ever been in. We all admired Alexia's ability to lie on burning wood. Or replenishing our thirst with local brews at The Mussel Inn. Communal Hangdog dinners were delicious and healthy. A social group, it felt like a team event, and yes Eric was satisfied he had done enough mileage by the end. The return trip is already planned.

A snowball called Anxiety

An attempt on Mt Travers, Labour Weekend
Words and pictures Peter Laurenson

Well that didn't work – this rock is no better than the sugary, treacherous snow I was craving respite from. My climbing companions Caro and Simon and I had been tentatively plugging upwards, out of the dawn, towards Mount Travers' northeast ridge. There had been no freeze overnight and, nagging at the backs of our minds, was a deteriorating weather forecast.

The snow was a problem. While the steps we kicked as we pot-holed upwards were deep, they sometimes gave way without warning. Our route took us up steep, exposed snow slopes, interspersed with stretches of shattered rock. Our ropes remained in the pack because there were no possibilities to put in solid protection. Our axes were really only good to aid balance – successful self arrest was very unlikely.

Our journey began on the Interislander two evenings before. Then our party was six – an Alpine Club trip led by Simon, our energetic Wellington Section President and organised by his industrious partner Caro. Nina, Ian and I are also Section members. I also had my youngest son Will along.

Approaching the most exposed section of snow and rock beneath the northeast ridge

Crossing Cook Strait we were still in a lovely weather window, due to close about midday on our intended summit day. The usual story authored by Mr Sod. A late night and fairly early start at St Arnaud saw us gliding across the mirror surface of Lake Rotoiti in Hamish's water taxi just after 8am. With pretty hefty packs, even with water taxi assistance, we still had a good 22kms to go to reach Upper Travers Hut, 700 vertical metres higher up.



I was a little nervous. I'd had keyhole surgery on my left knee exactly five weeks earlier, so I wasn't sure how well it would tolerate sustained weight and effort. As I write, three weeks on from our return, I now know that the timing of our trip wasn't exactly ideal for my recovery, but Voltaren kept pain and inflammation at bay very effectively during our four day journey.

We sweated our way up beside the Travers River under a cobalt sky. It was hot, so the cover of gladey beech forest for much of the way was a blessing. We got our first good look at the top four hundred or so metres of Mount Travers before John Tait Hut, at a bend in the river where a slip had taken out a section of the trail. It looked muscular – a classic looking summit.

After a pause for lunch at John Tait Hut, roughly the halfway point, we soldiered on. By the time everyone had arrived at Upper Travers Hut it was nearly time for dinner. Situated amongst trees just below the treeline and commanding an expansive view back down valley, with the eastern flanks of Travers soaring above, the generously proportioned hut is a beautiful place to stay.



An early glimpse of the top 400 or so metres of Mt Travers' southern aspect

After sorting out our gear it was an early dive into our sleeping bags to catch a few of the zeds lost the previous evening and to be ready for a 3am wakeup. At the sound of the alarm I peeked out to see, aside from the multitudes of twinkling stars, a completely clear sky. This was Will's first alpine start. He discovered how unappealing breakfast can be so early in the morning but, to offset that, he also enjoyed the otherworldly sensation of ascending terrain in the hovering pool of his head torch.

At about 1,500 metres we reached the snowline and soon donned our crampons. This is where our first problems emerged. Will's crampons wouldn't stay in place. I'd fitted them properly the night before, but I hadn't done as well in fitting his feet to my spare trekking boots. There was just too much give and they kept popping off.

As I cursed myself for my stupidity, Nina announced that she was not feeling well – possibly a dose of norovirus that had been doing the rounds recently. She was considering turning around and, when Ian heard all this, he also decided that perhaps our intended route might be a bit beyond his burning thighs on this particular dawn.

So, as the first inkling of a new day began to backlight the St Arnaud Range across the valley, three headed back down to the hut and three continued up. I am eternally grateful to Nina and Ian for going down with Will. For a moment there I thought my climb was over before it had really started. And as we progressed higher, my gratitude only magnified as I realised that, on this day, the route would have been unacceptably dangerous for Will.

As the others' head torch beams grew smaller and smaller below us, Simon, Caro and I headed north and up to a broad shoulder at 1,880m. On the shoulder we enjoyed an expansive dawn view across to the St Arnaud Range and down the Travers Valley.

The view north from the north east ridge, with Mt Cupola (2,260m, far left), Mt Hopeless (2,278m, left), the Travers Valley in fog and the St Arnaud Range, right



Climbing Weetbix at about 2,000m

From the shoulder we lost about fifty metres as we sidled around to the next snow field, giving us access to the northeast ridge, just beneath a 2,127m highpoint. As we climbed, the gradient increased and the sun's first rays began to make their softening and loosening effects felt.

At 1,900m we paused beneath a rock buttress on the lip of a tiny schrund to rearrange gear and discuss our next move. Simon lead up through steep snow around patches of rock while I waited a bit to get some photos. By the time I caught them up we were all starting to feel the early emotional impacts of sustained and increasing exposure. I led on through and decided to test my theory about the rock looking friendlier than the snow at that point.

I soon realised that, while the rock made a convincing impersonation of Weetbix, like the snow, it was definitely not to be relied upon for safe handholds or footings. "How far to the ridge" was Caro's hopeful call below me. "Can't be far now, but I still can't see the top yet". Another stint on snow and then Weetbix later and I still couldn't see the ridge directly above me. I could, however, see it to my right, just a careful traverse away, so that's where I headed.



As I reached the end of the traverse and gained the ridge at 2,070m, I noticed how fog had filled the Travers Valley and the sky above had filled with brooding, spectacularly beautiful clouds. It was very nice to relax for a bit on safe ground as I watched Simon, then Caro make their way across the traverse. When they both joined me we commiserated about how the sustained, un-protectable exposure had incidiously broken our resolve. It was as though our anxiety had slowly snowballed to the point where our thoughts were no longer about the summit. As we took in the deteriorating weather, which appeared to be bearing out the unfavourable forecast, we made the call that it was time to find a way down that didn't involve down climbing what we'd just come up.

Once that decision was made we discussed a couple of descent options while munching on some calories. While Caro was in favour of a retreat down Summit Creek, in pursuit of less knee effort, I argued for a much shorter route off the eastern side of the ridge. "I reckon that long tongue of flat snow coming off the ridge down there at about 1,950m looks like a friendly ramp. Shall we head for that guys?"

The section of ridge between us and the "friendly ramp" was mostly broken rock on a moderate gradient, so we felt the tension fall away as we enjoyed the views as we descended. At the ramp though Caro was unimpressed, as indeed was I. The ramp was no longer at all friendly, so Simon suggested another exit point further down the ridge. His option turned out to be partly friendly but, after running the ropes out to their full extent on a somewhat awkward abseil, Simon discovered that the next pitch was less friendly and also un-protectable. So back up he came and further down the ridge we went.

Soon we pitched, more for practise than necessity, a rope length down a snow chute on to a broad snow field one further over from the one we'd ascended that morning. It was then just a plod back around the 1,600m contour until Upper Traverse Hut came into view. Back in the Hut about 3.30pm Travers' summit was shrouded in swirling cloud and the first rain drops began to fall. It's always disappointing not to reach the top, but at least this made us feel like we'd made the right call to bail when we did.

Will was waiting for us, explaining that after having taken a jaunt up to Travers Saddle with Nina and Ian, they had decided to head down valley and would rejoin us in two days. While it would have been nice to have their company, that evening we savoured the luxury of having the entire hut to ourselves, despite it being Labour weekend.

Next morning dawned crisp and clear – better than the morning of our climb, despite the weather forecast suggesting otherwise.

The south ridge and summit of Mt Travers, viewed from above Travers Saddle. Mt Cupola is just left partly in cloud

Simon, Caro and I headed for Travers Saddle and soon discovered that there had also been a freeze overnight. With the clarity of hindsight we realised that this should have been our summit day. "Buggar! Ah well" we thought, "might as well make the most of the situation and go check out the grade three route up from the Saddle, along the South Ridge".

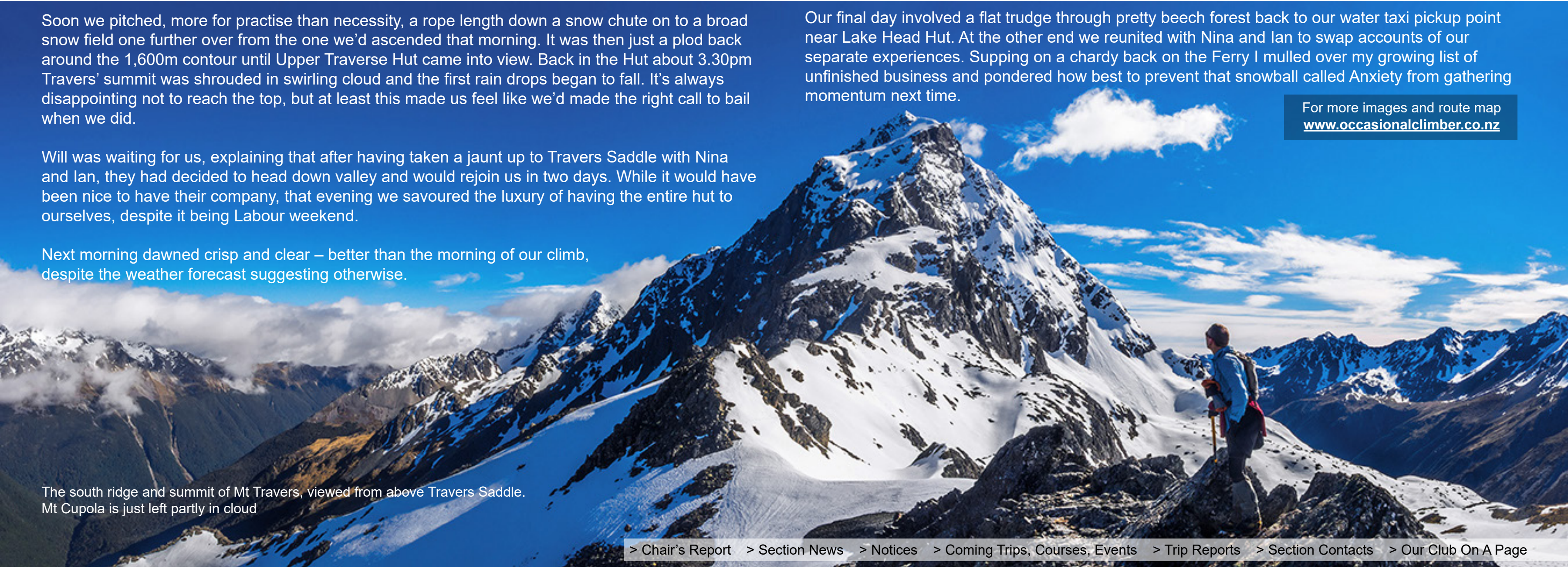
We only had walking axes and no rope, so Simon and I just went as far as the conditions would permit, while Caro enjoyed a bit of down time soaking up her surroundings below the Saddle. After a steep front point onto a broad shoulder at 2,000m we called it a day. From our high point we could see the way to the notch guarding access to the summit snow fields and felt that, on a good day, this could be a very rewarding and doable route. Maybe next time!

As we descended again to the Saddle we were surprised to see how quickly the snow had deteriorated again as the day wore on. But it was great to take in the beautiful views on and around the Saddle. As Simon said "any day in the mountains is a good day."

After lunch we bid farewell to Upper Travers Hut and headed down to John Tait Hut. En route we checked out Travers Falls, which was a nice surprise. Just a little down off the trail in a lovely, extensive goblin grotto of ferns and moss, it was definitely worth a visit. At John Tait Hut Labour weekend caught up with us in the form of a noisy, crowded Hut. But this only accentuated our fond memories of Upper Travers Hut.

Our final day involved a flat trudge through pretty beech forest back to our water taxi pickup point near Lake Head Hut. At the other end we reunited with Nina and Ian to swap accounts of our separate experiences. Supping on a chardy back on the Ferry I mulled over my growing list of unfinished business and pondered how best to prevent that snowball called Anxiety from gathering momentum next time.

For more images and route map
www.occasionalclimber.co.nz



Section Contacts

Powered by volunteers

We're always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. A lot goes on to keep our club going, virtually all powered by volunteers. On the back page is our "Club on a page" summary. It gives an at a glance description of all the things we do, how and why. Feel free to print a copy and pass it on to anyone who might be interested in becoming a member or volunteer. And if you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

A warm welcome to our new Committee members Keith, Guy, Blair and Joshua; and a grateful farewell to Elisha and Sandy.

Role	Name	Contact
Chair person	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
Secretary, gear custodian	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Treasurer	Vacant	
Trip co-ordinator	Eric Duggan	021 350 161
Section nights, Vertigo, Photocomp	Peter Laurenson	021 446 725
Social media	Marie Kelly	
Club liaison	Keith Munro	
Library, Projects	Alex Waterworth	
General Committee	Matt Pemberton	
General Committee	Guy Dubuis	
General Committee	Blair Bryant	
General Committee	Joshua Mouat	
Patron	John Nankervis	



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New routes every week*

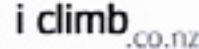
\$1000 worth of new holds in Jan/Feb 2012
New pad in "Da Cave" allowing safe aggressive bouldering

Creating happiness through better climbing

* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.



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info@hangdog.co.nz
www.hangdog.co.nz



Simond alpine equipment direct from the importer



all crampons include anti-balling plates and crampon bag

Ocelot \$115	MXC 820 \$230	Makalu \$255	Caiman \$230
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For quick access to our Section's page on the NZAC website, click or scan this QR code

WHAT WE DO

FOR MEMBERS

Facilities

- * Huts
- * Gear
- * Library
- * Discounts

Training

- * Level 1- 3
winter skills
- * Summer rock
- * Instructors

Climbing trips

- * Section
- * National
- * International

FOR MEMBERS AND WIDER PUBLIC

Publications

- * Website
- * Social media
- * Vertigo
- * Guide books

Events

- * Banff mountain
film festival
- * Reel Rock
- * Photo comp

Networking

- * Section nights
- * Conferences
and meetings
- * Lobbying

HOW WE DO IT

Organise, encourage, support, enable

Inform, entertain, promote

OUR RESOURCES

Volunteer time and capabilities, income from events and gear hire, national office support, sponsorship

WHY WE DO IT

Connecting & developing more climbing & mountaineering people, knowledge, skills & experience, thereby ...

... building
lifelong
friendships

... protecting
and improving
access to
alpine places

... sustaining
and growing
climbing and
mountaineering
achievement

... enhancing
alpine
safety

... building
appreciation,
enjoyment and
protection of
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